

The message “this is for you”: theorising how users and recommender systems interact in the personalisation of online environments

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? Research problem and motivation:

- What role do people play in constructing the personalisation they experience as an environmental quality?
- Algorithms are usually seen as the dominant driver of personalisation. The work that people perform when interacting with algorithms in order for personalisation to materialise is often overlooked, however.

💡 Key arguments and findings:

- People play a constitutive role in creating the feeling and appearance of personalisation in online environments.
- Personalisation is continuously constructed *in situ* and thus cannot be conceived as fixed environmental quality.
- Awareness, literacy, and prior experience are key mediators of people’s ability to personalise their environments.

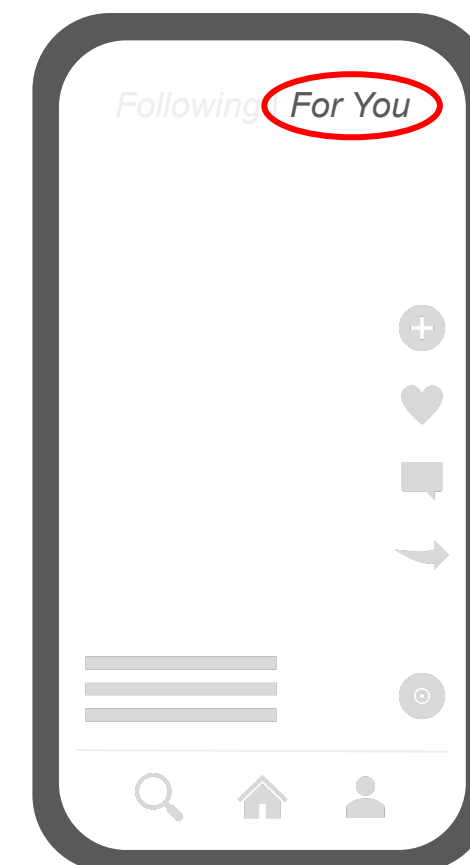
🔧 Research method and context:

- Larger digital ethnography of TikTok consumption amongst young adults in the United Kingdom. Fieldwork took place over one and a half years (from 2020 to 2021).
- Main body of data is a series of interviews with 30 young adults, conducted in three month intervals for 1 year. Additionally, walkthroughs of the Tik Tok app (6 months), mappings of participants’ polymedia environment, and participant observations of them scrolling through TikTok.

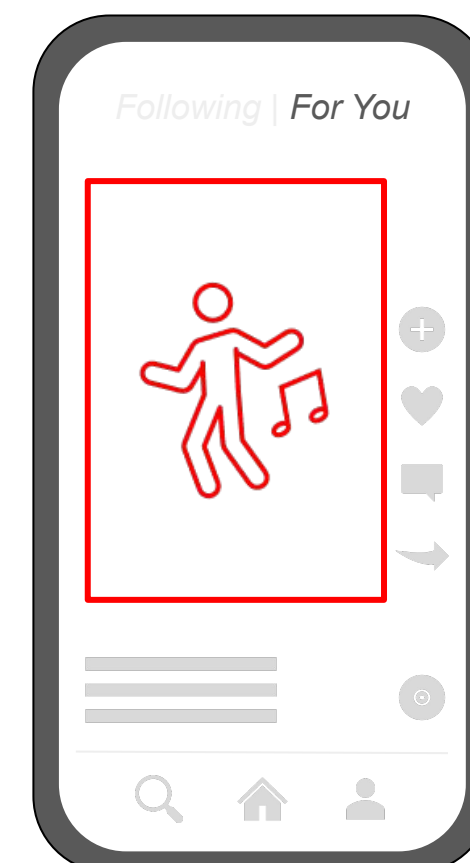
📖 Theoretical background:

- Study follows an audience studies (e.g., Seiter et al. 1989) and algorithm studies (e.g., Siles 2023) approach focussed on investigating how people navigate media environments.
- Philosophically grounded in the tradition of human-machine interaction (e.g., Suchman 2007) that is concerned with understanding the foundational dynamics that govern how people can interact with machines.

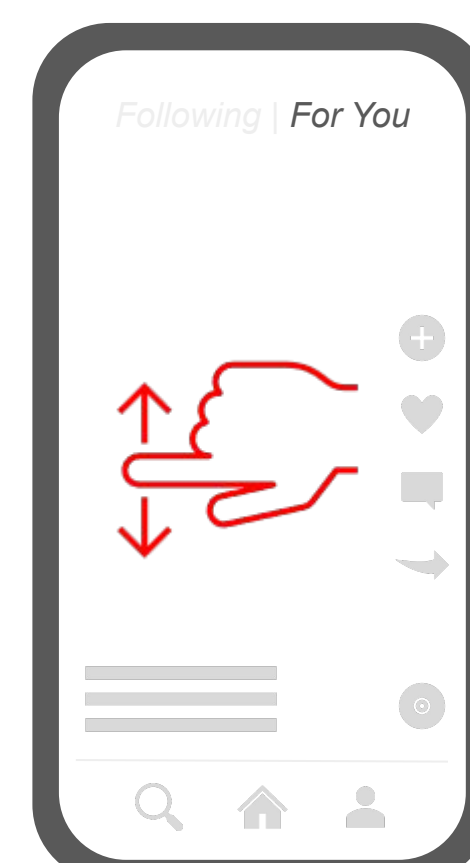
Process: personalisation as an environmental quality that is performatively enacted



Framing the action: for participants, it was obvious that TikTok is a personalised environment. Elements such as the branding and context of content feeds communicate a message that what is shown is meant “for you”. This shapes how people interact with these environments, understand their role within them, and sets expectations for their experience.

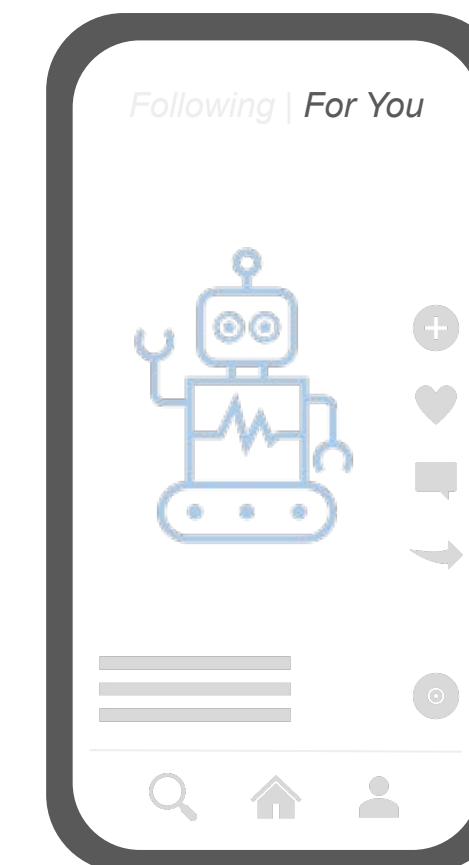


Acting on cues: people read through content feeds guided by the message “this is for you”. They actively look for cues in content that evokes a “for you” feeling. This is a performative action. Meaning, readers search for cues that allows them see their self reflected in recommend content, evoking a feeling of “for you”-ness.

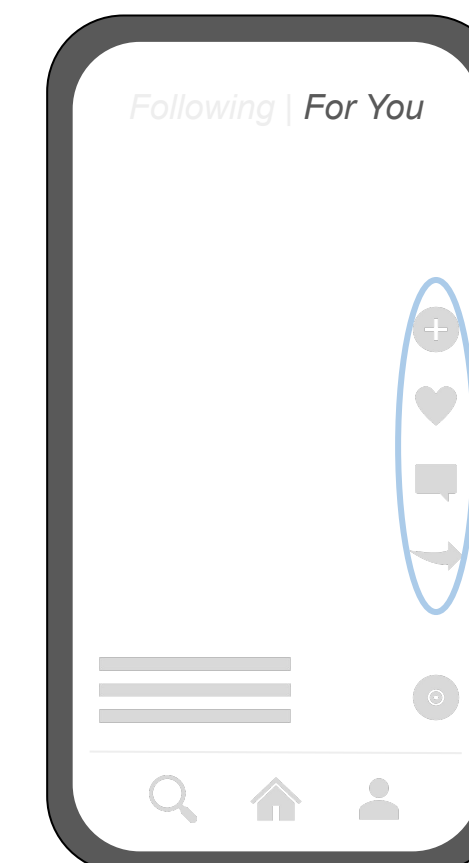


Enacting personalisation: people habitually navigate content feeds, skipping past “basic” videos and compressing them to a point that they become barely noticeable in the flow. This enacts an appearance of the environment as being personalised. During fieldwork, participants could be observed almost immediately knowing if a video would be “it” or “not it”.

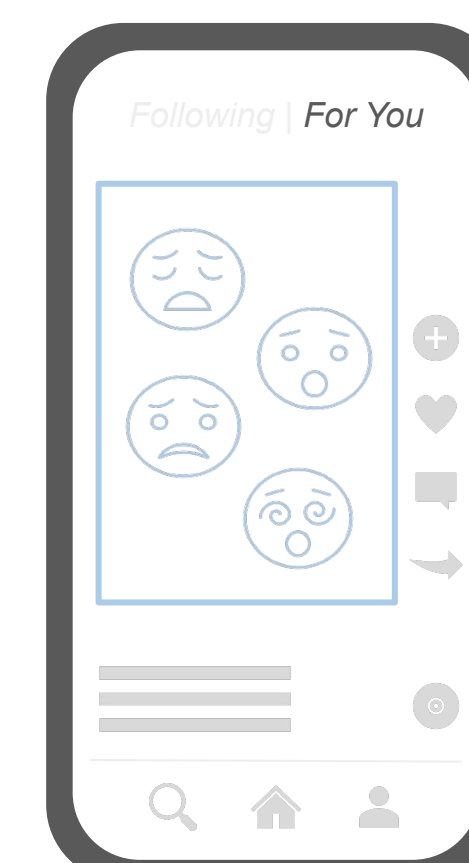
Mediators: personalisation as a continuous dialogue with the algorithm



“Seeing” the algorithm: when people are unaware that there is an algorithm actively making content suggestions, they cannot interact and communicate with it. Awareness for algorithms is thus a critical precondition mediating agentic capacities in the relationship and abilities to actively shape the experience of the environment.



“Speaking” with the algorithm: an (embodied) understanding for how to communicate with and be understood by algorithms is another vital mediator. During fieldwork, participants could be observed continuously experimenting with ways of communicatively responding to content recommended by the TikTok algorithm to them - e.g., by consciously liking, following, or leaving comments.



Learning how to cope with the algorithm: at times people perceive content as scarily specific, boring, or just irritating. In such moments, participants were pushed to reflect on their relationship and had to make sense of their feelings that threatened the continuity of the flow. Coping devices included turning to memes or conversing with friends and other users.